

JULIET

What devil art thou that dost torment me thus?
This torture should be roared in dismal hell.
Hath Romeo slain himself? Say thou but “ay,”
And that bare vowel I shall poison more
Than the death-darting eye of cockatrice.
I am not I if there be such an I,
Or those eyes shut that makes thee answer “ay.”
If he be slain, say “ay,” or if not, “no.”
Brief sounds determine of my weal or woe.
What kind of devil are you to torture me like this?

NURSE

I saw the wound, I saw it with mine eyes—
God save the mark!—here on his manly breast.
A piteous corse, a bloody piteous corse.
Pale, pale as ashes, all bedaubed in blood,
All in gore blood. I swoonèd at the sight.

1. What pun is being used here between “ay” and “I”? How is it being used for dramatic effect?

JULIET

Wilt thou be gone? It is not yet near day.
It was the nightingale, and not the lark,
That pierced the fearful hollow of thine ear.
Nightly she sings on yon pomegranate tree.
Believe me, love, it was the nightingale.

ROMEO

It was the lark, the herald of the morn,
No nightingale. Look, love, what envious streaks
Do lace the severing clouds in yonder east.
Night's candles are burnt out, and jocund day
Stands tiptoe on the misty mountain tops.
I must be gone and live, or stay and die.

JULIET

Yon light is not daylight, I know it, I.
It is some meteor that the sun exhales
To be to thee this night a torchbearer,
And light thee on thy way to Mantua.
Therefore stay yet. Thou need'st not to be gone.

ROMEO

Let me be ta'en. Let me be put to death.
I am content, so thou wilt have it so.
I'll say yon grey is not the morning's eye.
'Tis but the pale reflex of Cynthia's brow.
Nor that is not the lark, whose notes do beat
The vaulty heaven so high above our heads.
I have more care to stay than will to go.
Come, death, and welcome! Juliet wills it so.—
How is 't, my soul? Let's talk. It is not day. (Act 3, Scene 5, 186)

1. Explain what is happening in this scene. Why does Juliet think it is the nightingale? Why does Romeo say it's the lark, but then agree that it's not the morning and say "Let me be put to death"?
2. Rewrite one paragraph in this scene in your own words.

3. Is it good to be so in love that you deny reality (as Juliet says it is the nightingale and not the lark) and risk danger to your life (as Romeo does when he says he will stay and be executed)? Write an argumentative essay arguing that it is good or that it is not good to be so in love. Remember to write a thesis statement, context, examples, analysis, and acknowledgement/conclusion.